STATE OF MICHIGAN
DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES
LANSING

GRETCHEN WHITMER
GOVERNOR

ROBERT GORDON
DIRECTOR

MEMORANDUM

DATE: January 23, 2021

TO: Robert Ernst, University of Michigan
Danielle Sheen, University of Michigan
Dyan Jenkins Ali, University of Michigan
Emily Toth Martin, University of Michigan

FROM: Dr. Joneigh Khaldun,
Chief Medical Executive and Chief Deputy Director

CC: Mark Schlissel, University of Michigan
Preeti Malani, University of Michigan
Chris Kolb, University of Michigan
Jimena Loveluck, Washtenaw County Health Department
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SUBJECT: SARS-CoV-2 B.1.1.7

Staff from the Washtenaw County Health Department are continuing to monitor the outbreak of SAR-CoV-2 B.1.1.7 variant virus infections in the University of Michigan (UM) community. To date, B 1.1.7 variant cases have been confirmed or is suspected in members of multiple UM athletic teams. As you know, compared to the wild-type virus, the B.1.1.7 variant is approximately 50 percent more transmissible, leading to faster spread of the virus, potentially increased numbers of cases, and additional hospitalizations and deaths. Therefore, continued identification of this variant, particularly in a campus setting, requires additional levels of public health intervention.

Given continued transmission of the variant within UM Athletic programs, MDHHS is recommending a very aggressive strategy that exceeds current program efforts that had been designed around the wild-type virus. The core of this strategy places ALL UM varsity athletic programs in quarantine until further notice and up to 14 days from today's date. This quarantine will include clearly delineated restrictions AND assurance monitoring.

1. Cease athletic events and practices, effective immediately.
    a. All team members and associated household members, as well as identified close contacts of cases, must immediately isolate/quarantine, starting from the date of this letter. All athletic teams are to be restricted from any outside gatherings or contact with non-team members for the duration of this quarantine.

   b. Immediately interview ALL individuals with positive test results in past two weeks to identify ANY possible venues for transmission.
   c. Immediately conduct PCR testing in all team members and conduct genetic sequencing of any resulting COVID-19 isolates.
   d. Conduct face-to-face monitoring of quarantined individuals twice daily and provide enhanced education on the transmissibility of this new variant.
   e. Conduct 3-day a week PCR testing during quarantine.
   f. All cases linked to this athletic outbreak should be considered to be, and treated as, variant infections, pending confirmatory testing.

2. Re-interview other cases on campus to identify possible epidemiologic links to B 1.1.7 cases and additional contacts for quarantine.
   a. Utilize recommendations above for any individuals with exposure to the University of Michigan Athletic system outbreak.

3. Provide individuals quarantining and isolating in other outbreaks on campus enhanced education on the transmissibility of this new variant and the importance of adhering to isolation and quarantine protocols. Sequence all positive results from additional outbreaks on campus.

4. Continue to implement the other recommendations in the enhanced campus-wide testing strategy we recommended on 1/21/21, including:
   a. If variant infection is detected or suspected in members of campus organizations, provide PCR testing for all members of the impacted organized group, two times weekly, and twice daily face-to-face check-in with quarantined members.
   b. Delivery of education and on-site antigen testing to off-campus areas of student housing with identified variant cases of COVID-19 infection (“Hot Spots”)
      i. Provision of letters and fact sheets that describe the variant infections and announce testing opportunities.
      ii. Pop-up testing center implementation in geographic range of the Hot Spots. Antigen or PCR testing available three times/week.
   c. Facilitate and encourage testing (antigen or PCR) of entire campus community with messaging and educational materials about the B.1.1.7 variant and the potential of other variant infections.
   d. Furthermore, in addition to testing, we recommend quarantine for at least 10 days for any students returning to campus from visits out of state or out of the country.

5. Proactive messaging to the University community about the presence of the variant should encourage people to reduce their activities to necessary interactions only (i.e., not holding household gatherings, do not have in person dining).

Our path forward is challenging but addressing the occurrence of B 1.1.7 variant will reduce the longer-term impact on the University and surrounding community. Thank you for your commitment to the health and safety of your staff, students, and the broader Washtenaw County and Michigan communities. We look forward to continuing to work with you and the Washtenaw County Health Department.